Stop 3: Forum Romanum & Sacra Via

Historical, Archaeological & Cultural Field Guide • Regal, Republican & Imperial Eras (8th Century BC – 7th Century AD)

1. Executive Historical Overview & Urban Topography

The Forum Romanum was the political, religious, judicial, and triumphal heart of ancient Rome for well over a millennium. Traversed by the sacred basalt flagstones of the Via Sacra, this valley witnessed royal funerals, Republican senatorial debates, triumphal parades laden with foreign spoils, and the monumental marble transformations of the Roman Empire.

Topographical Context & Geomorphology

Located at **Via della Salara Vecchia 5/6 (Campidoglio / Palatine Valley), Rome** (Coordinates: 41.8925° N, 12.4853° E), Forum Romanum & Sacra Via occupies a pivotal zone within the ancient pomerial and Campus Martius/Forum basin network. Archaeological core sampling demonstrates how early Republican builders adapted to seasonal Tiber River flooding by raising tufa podiums and installing subterranean drainage channels connected to Rome's primary cloacae.

RAG Indexing Summary: *Document Type: Historical & Cultural Guide | Stop Number: 3 | Primary Site: Forum Romanum & Sacra Via | Era: Regal, Republican & Imperial Eras (8th Century BC – 7th Century AD) | Key Monuments: Curia Julia & Comitium, Arch of Septimius Severus, Temple of Saturn & Aerarium, Basilica Julia & Basilica Aemilia.*

Chronological Stratigraphy Summary

Phase / Period	Key Monumental Intervention	Primary Building Materials
Archaic / Early Republic	Initial consecration and tufa altar foundations at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via	Cappellaccio & Grotta Oscura Tufa
Middle–Late Republic	Expansion of Curia Julia & Comitium and Arch of Septimius Severus after military triumphs	Monteverde Tufa, Travertine & Stucco
High Empire (Augustan–Severan)	Marble revetment, raised travertine paving, and fire restorations	Carrara, Pentelic & Polychrome Marbles

2. Origins, Votive Dedications & Republican Evolution

During the Republican expansion of Rome across the Italian peninsula and the Mediterranean, Forum Romanum & Sacra Via served as a canvas for aristocratic competition (nobilitas). Victorious generals (imperatores) vowed temples (vota) on the battlefield in exchange for divine favor, financing construction ex manubiis (from the spoils of war) upon their return to the capital.

Primary Focus: Curia Julia & Comitium (44–29 BC (Restored AD 284 by Diocletian))

The official brick Senate House begun by Julius Caesar and completed by Augustus. Preserves its original polychrome opus sectile marble floor and bronze doors replicas.

Primary Focus: Arch of Septimius Severus (AD 203)

Triple-bay white Proconnesian marble triumphal arch celebrating Roman victories over the Parthian Empire in 194/195 and 197–199 AD.

Ritual Function & Triumphal Processions

Every temple precinct within Forum Romanum & Sacra Via possessed a dies natalis (anniversary of its dedication) marked in the Fasti Antiates Maiores. Because Roman sacrificial ritual occurred outdoors under the open sky, monumental U-shaped altars with projecting wings were positioned directly at the foot of the frontal access stairs, aligning priest, victim, and cult statue along a single liturgical axis.

Field Observation Note: *Examine the surviving base moldings around Curia Julia & Comitium. Notice the distinct cyma reversa profile typical of Republican Italic podiums before Hellenistic Greek profiles became dominant following the conquests of Syracuse (212 BC) and Macedonia (146 BC).*

3. Monumental Catalog & Imperial Transformations

As the Roman Republic gave way to the Principate under Augustus and later the Antonine and Severan dynasties, Forum Romanum & Sacra Via underwent profound architectural remodeling. Devastating urban fires—particularly those of 111 BC, AD 64, AD 80, and AD 191—compelled emperors to raise ground levels and encase older tufa structures in imported marble.

Monument Analysis: Temple of Saturn & Aerarium (497 BC (Rebuilt 42 BC & AD 283))

Eight towering granite Ionic columns at the foot of the Capitoline Hill; served as the state treasury (Aerarium Saturni) and center of the December Saturnalia festival.

Monument Analysis: Basilica Julia & Basilica Aemilia (54 BC – AD 14 / 179 BC)

Flanking judicial and banking halls of the main piazza; Basilica Aemilia still displays green copper stains from coins melted onto its marble floor during the Visigothic sack of AD 410.

Monument Analysis: Temple of Vesta, Atrium Vestae & Temple of Divus Julius (29 BC – 3rd Century AD)

Sacred hearth of Rome tended by the six Vestal Virgins alongside the semicircular altar enclosing the cremation pyre of Julius Caesar.

Architectural Synthesis: *Spanning from the Lapis Niger (an archaic 6th-century BC black marble shrine inscribed in early Latin bustrophedon script) to the Column of Phocas (AD 608, the last imperial monument erected in the Forum), the site illustrates the transition from peperino tufa and wood temples to monumental Proconnesian, Cipollino, and Pavonazzetto marble engineering.*

4. Roman Engineering, Structural Mechanics & Lithic Provenance

The monuments at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via provide a textbook sequence of Roman structural engineering, illustrating the mastery of ashlar masonry (opus quadratum), concrete core construction (opus caementicium), brick facing (opus latericium), and polychrome geometric marble paving (opus sectile).

Lithic & Material Provenance Table

Material / Stone	Ancient Quarry Source	Structural / Decorative Application at Site
Lapis Tiburtinus (Travertine)	Tibur (Modern Tivoli)	Load-bearing piers, column capitals, steps, and Imperial pavement slabs
Tufo Lionato / Monteverde	Aniene Valley & Janiculum slopes	Temple podium cores, Republican altar bases, and drainage channels
Marmor Lunense / Pentelicum	Carrara (Italy) & Mt. Pentelicus (Attica)	Corinthian entablatures, acrolithic cult statues, and carved relief panels
Pozzolana (Pulvis Puteolanus)	Alban Hills & Campanian volcanic beds	Hydraulic mortar binding opus caementicium vaults and foundations

Structural Load & Hydraulic Management

Roman architects utilized relieving arches (archi di scarico) concealed within brick walls to channel vertical dead loads away from lintels and onto massive corner piers. Subsurface travertine gutters around Forum Romanum & Sacra Via captured rainwater from temple roofs, routing runoff directly into underlying collectors.

5. Key Historical Figures, Statesmen & Political Drama

History at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via was shaped by the ambitions, rivalries, and religious piety of Rome's most influential consuls, dictators, emperors, and architects. Below are the four primary historical protagonists linked directly to the surviving archaeological fabric of this stop:

• Marcus Tullius Cicero

Orator and Consul who delivered the Philippics from the Rostra; after his proscription in 43 BC, Mark Antony nailed his head and hands to the speaker's platform.

• Emperor Augustus (Octavian)

Transformed the Republican marketplace into a dynastic marble showcase centered on the Temple of the Deified Julius and his Parthian Arch.

• Titus Flavius Vespasianus (Titus)

Honored on the Arch of Titus (AD 81) along the Summa Sacra Via depicting the spoils of the Second Temple of Jerusalem, including the seven-branched Menorah.

• Maxentius & Constantine I

Rival emperors responsible for the colossal brick-and-concrete Basilica of Maxentius and Constantine, whose coffered vaults inspired Renaissance St. Peter's.

Primary Ancient Literary Sources: *Suetonius (De Vita Caesarum), Plutarch (Parallel Lives), Livy (Ab Urbe Condita), Cassius Dio (Roman History), and Vitruvius (De Architectura) all record direct eyewitness or archival accounts of the ceremonies and political crises at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via.*

6. Epigraphy, Latin Inscriptions & Sculptural Finds

Latin epigraphy provides the chronological backbone for identifying temples and imperial restorations at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via. Monumental inscriptions were carved using V-cut trenches (litterae aureae) often fitted with gilded bronze letters fastened via lead-soldered tangs into sockets still visible on the stone architraves.

Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum (CIL) & Sculptural Record

The attic of the Arch of Septimius Severus displays original bronze peg holes where Geta's name was replaced with 'OPTIMIS FORTISSIMISQVE PRINCIPIBVS'. On the Arch of Titus, the inscription reads 'SENATVS POPVLVSQVE ROMANVS DIVO TITO DIVI VESPASIANI F VESPASIANO AVGVSTO'.

Numismatic & Relief Iconography

Roman Republican denarii and Imperial sestertii frequently minted reverse dies depicting the facades of monuments at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via. These coins allow archaeologists to reconstruct lost pedimental sculptures, acroteria, and bronze grilles that vanished during late antique spoliation.

Epigraphic Reading Tip for Visitors: *Look closely at the spacing of interpuncts (triangular dots · between words) and the absence of 'U' (written as 'V') and 'J' (written as 'I'). Erasures where the stone surface sits slightly recessed indicate damnatio memoriae ordered by the Roman Senate.*

7. Daily Civic Life, Sacrificial Liturgy & Acoustic Space

At its peak in the 1st and 2nd centuries AD, Forum Romanum & Sacra Via was not a silent ruin of bare stone and brick, but a sensory kaleidoscope of painted stucco, fragrant frankincense smoke, bronze statuary gleaming in the sun, and crowds of citizens, senators, freedmen, and foreign envoys.

The Mechanics of Roman Public Sacrifice (Sacrificium)

Public rites opened with the herald crying 'Favete linguis!' (Keep a reverent silence!) while flute players (tibicines) drowned out inauspicious street noises. The officiating magistrate, with his toga pulled over his head (capite velato), sprinkled salted spelt flour (mola salsa) and wine over the altar before the victimarius struck the sacrificial animal and haruspices inspected the entrails.

Commercial & Legal Rhythms Around the Precinct

Surrounding the sacred core of Forum Romanum & Sacra Via, porticoes sheltered bankers (argentarii), bookbinders, scribes, and flower sellers weaving garlands for temple offerings. Marble game boards (tabulae lusoriae) scratched directly into the pavement steps by waiting clerks and loafers remain visible on site today.

8. Medieval Transformation, Renaissance Rediscovery & Modern Excavations

Following the collapse of imperial administration in the West (5th–6th centuries AD), Forum Romanum & Sacra Via entered a millennium-long phase of adaptive reuse. While exposed marble columns were frequently burned into slaked lime (calce) in medieval kilns (calcare), structures converted into Christian churches or baronial fortresses survived remarkably intact.

Christian Consecration & Baronial Fortifications

During the 8th through 13th centuries, powerful Roman families—including the Frangipane, Pierleoni, Savelli, and Conti—incorporated the stout Roman walls of Forum Romanum & Sacra Via into fortified towers and diaconiae. Renaissance architects including Baldassarre Peruzzi, Antonio da Sangallo, and Andrea Palladio measured and sketched these ruins, transmitting their proportions directly into 16th-century European classicism.

19th–21st Century Archaeological Campaigns

Systematic stratigraphic excavations led by Rodolfo Lanciani, Giacomo Boni, Antonio Muñoz, and the modern Sovrintendenza Capitolina ai Beni Culturali stripped away post-antique overburden, stabilized brick vaults with reversible titanium ties, and opened buried subterranean corridors to the public.

9. Step-by-Step On-Site Viewing Itinerary & Vantage Points

To maximize your 45-to-60-minute visit at Forum Romanum & Sacra Via, follow this sequential clockwise architectural circuit designed to trace the site from its earliest Republican foundations to its high Imperial climax:

Step	Vantage Point / Station	What to Look For (Key Visual Detail)
01	Primary Overview & Curia Julia & Comitium	Compare the archaic tufa ashlar blocks with the elevated imperial travertine pavement level.
02	Arch of Septimius Severus & Altar Precinct	Inspect the U-shaped sacrificial altar moldings and surviving fluted column shafts.
03	Temple of Saturn & Aerarium & Basilica Julia & Basilica Aemilia	Observe the transition to Hellenistic marble capitals and circular/pseudoperipteral layouts.
04	Temple of Vesta, Atrium Vestae & Temple of Divus Julius & Epigraphic Zone	Read the monumental Latin inscriptions and trace the Roman brick relieving arches.

Golden Hour & Photography Guidance

Optimal raking sunlight strikes the travertine and tufa facades of Forum Romanum & Sacra Via between 08:30–10:00 AM and again during late afternoon golden hour (16:30–18:00), bringing out deep chisel marks and relief shadows.

10. Practical Visitor Logistics, Accessibility & Next-Stop Transit

Use the reference sheet below when planning arrival times, ticketing, accessibility routes, and walking transfers from **Stop 3: Forum Romanum & Sacra Via** to the next destination on your Roman itinerary.

Logistic Category	Verified Visitor Information
Exact Address & Zone	Via della Salara Vecchia 5/6 (Campidoglio / Palatine Valley), Rome (41.8925° N, 12.4853° E)
Recommended Visit Duration	45–75 minutes (Perimeter viewing + interior archaeological walk)
Best Time of Day to Visit	09:00 AM opening slot or 90 minutes prior to sunset to avoid tour bus peaks
Accessibility & Footwear	Ancient uneven basalt (sampietrini/basoli) and travertine steps; sturdy walking shoes essential
Water & Rest Facilities	Free potable cast-iron Roman Nasone drinking fountain located within 80 meters of the piazza

Essential Glossary of Architectural Terms Used in This Guide

• **Opus Caementicium:** Roman hydraulic concrete mixed from lime, pozzolana volcanic ash, and stone aggregate (caementa).
• **Opus Quadratum:** Ashlar masonry of squared stone blocks laid in regular courses without mortar, clamped with iron/lead.
• **Opus Sectile:** Luxury floor or wall decoration formed from precision-cut thin slabs of polychrome marble.
• **Pomerium:** The sacred religious and legal boundary of the city of Rome within which weapons were forbidden.
• **Damnatio Memoriae:** Official senatorial condemnation erasing a disgraced figure's name and likeness from monuments.